Modal verbs: can, must, should

Nombre: _____ Fecha: _____

Qué vas a aprender

- Use can and can't for ability, permission and possibility
- Use must and mustn't for rules and obligation
- Use should and shouldn't to give advice (consejos)
- Remember the grammar of modal verbs: no -s, no to, no do

Para pensar

Tres frases: «Puedo nadar», «Debes llevar casco» y «Deberías beber agua». ¿Qué diferencia hay entre «debes» y «deberías»?

Explicación

What are modal verbs?

Modal verbs are special verbs that go before another verb to add a meaning: ability, permission, obligation or advice. The most common are **can**, **must** and **should**.

They have three golden rules: **1)** the same form for all persons: «he **can**», not «he cans»; **2)** the next verb has no *to*: «I can swim», not «I can to swim»; **3)** no *do/does* in negatives and questions: «I **can't**», «**Can** you...?». **En castellano:** son como «poder» y «deber», pero sin conjugar.



Can: ability

We use can to talk about **ability** (capacidad, saber hacer algo): «I **can** ride a bike», «My sister **can** speak three languages», «Penguins **can't** fly, but they **can** swim very well».

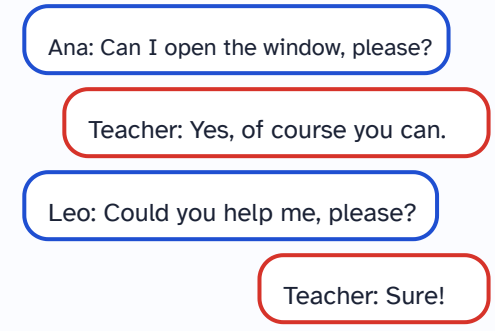
For the **past** we use could / couldn't: «When I was five I **could** swim, but I **couldn't** read». Questions and short answers: «**Can** you play the guitar?» – «Yes, I can. / No, I can't». **En castellano:** «can» traduce «sé» o «puedo»: «I can swim» = «sé nadar».

	Example
+	I can swim.
–	Penguins can't fly.
?	Can you skate?
past	I could read at 6.

Can: permission and requests

We also use can to ask for and give **permission** (permiso): «**Can** I go to the toilet, please?» – «Yes, you can». «You **can't** use your phone in class». And to make **requests** (pedir cosas): «**Can** you help me, please?».

A more polite way is could: «**Could** I open the window?», «**Could** you pass me the salt, please?». **Consejo:** en clase, pedir las cosas con *Can I..., please?* o *Could I...?* es muy educado.



Must and mustn't: rules

We use must for **obligation** and strong rules: «You **must** wear a seat belt», «Students **must** be on time». We use mustn't (must not) for **prohibition** (prohibido): «You **mustn't** run in the corridor», «You **mustn't** feed the animals».

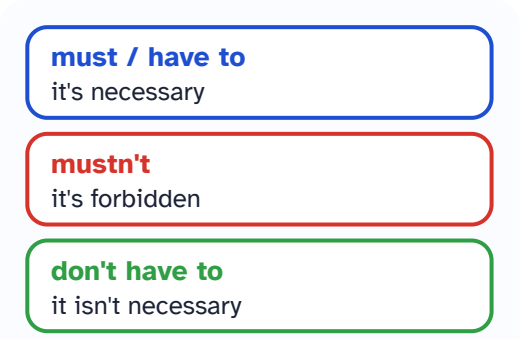
Careful: *mustn't* means «it is forbidden», not «it isn't necessary». **En castellano:** «you must» = «debes / tienes que»; «you mustn't» = «no debes / está prohibido».



Have to and don't have to

Have to also means obligation, often rules from other people: «I **have to** do my homework every day», «She **has to** wear a uniform». It changes with the person (has to) and uses do/does: «**Do** you **have to** get up early?».

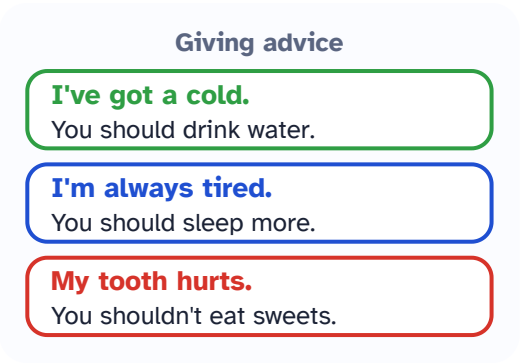
Don't have to means it is **not necessary**: «Tomorrow is Saturday, so I **don't have to** go to school». Compare: «You **mustn't** touch it» (prohibido) and «You **don't have to** come» (no hace falta). **En castellano:** «no tienes que» no es lo mismo que «no debes».



Should: advice

We use should to give **advice** (consejos) and say what is a good idea: «You **should** go to bed early», «You look tired. You **should** rest». Shouldn't says it's a bad idea: «You **shouldn't** eat so many sweets».

To ask for advice: «What **should** I do?», «**Should** I tell the teacher?». **En castellano:** «should» es «deberías». Es más suave que *must*: no es una norma, es una recomendación.



Choosing the right modal

Ask yourself: is it an **ability**? → **can**. Is it **permission**? → **can / could**. Is it a **rule** or **obligation**? → **must / have to**. Is it **forbidden**? → **mustn't**. Is it **advice**? → **should**.

Examples: «You **must** stop at a red light» (rule). «You **should** wear a coat, it's cold» (advice). «I **can** touch my toes» (ability). «You **mustn't** use the lift in a fire» (forbidden).

Meaning	Modal
ability	can / can't
permission	can / could
obligation	must / have to
advice	should

Reading: rules at the swimming pool

Read the poster: «**SWIMMING POOL RULES.** You **must** have a shower before you swim. You **must** wear a swimming cap. You **mustn't** run around the pool. You **mustn't** eat in the water. Children under eight **must** be with an adult. You **can** use the slide from 11 to 1. **Advice:** you **should** wear flip-flops and you **should** drink water after swimming.»

Find two obligations, two prohibitions, one permission and one piece of advice.



Let's practise: class rules and advice

In groups, write the **rules** for your classroom: «We **must** listen when someone is speaking», «We **mustn't** shout», «We **can** read a book when we finish». Make a poster.

Then play «Problem and advice»: one student says a problem and the others give advice. «I can't sleep.» – «You **should** read a book», «You **shouldn't** use your tablet at night». **Consejo:** recuerda la regla de oro: después de un modal, el verbo va sin *to* y sin -s.



Modal verbs



Ejercicios

1. **Write two things you can do and one you can't.**

2. **Make a question: «You can speak French.»**

3. **Past: «I can read.» (when I was six)**

4. **Ask for permission to go out.**

5. **Complete: «You ___ smoke in hospitals.»**

6. **Complete: «It's Sunday. I ___ get up early.» (no hace falta)**

7. **Give advice: «I've got a headache.»**

8. **Correct: «She musts do her homework.»**

9. **Translate: «No deberías ver tanta tele.»**

10. **Write three rules for a library.**

Practica

1. **«I ___ swim.» (sé nadar)**
   - **A)** must
   - **B)** can
   - **C)** should
2. **«She ___ play the piano.»**
   - **A)** cans
   - **B)** can to
   - **C)** can
3. **«___ you ride a horse?»**
   - **A)** Can
   - **B)** Do you can
   - **C)** Does
4. **Past of «can» is...**
   - **A)** canned
   - **B)** did can
   - **C)** could
5. **«You ___ run in the corridor.» (prohibido)**
   - **A)** don't have to
   - **B)** mustn't
   - **C)** should
6. **«You look tired. You ___ go to bed.»**
   - **A)** should
   - **B)** mustn't
   - **C)** can't
7. **«don't have to» means...**
   - **A)** está prohibido
   - **B)** no hace falta
   - **C)** no sabes
8. **«___ I go to the toilet, please?»**
   - **A)** Must

B) Should

C) Can

9. **«He ___ wear a uniform.» (obligación, he)**

A) has to

B) have to

C) must to

10. **Which is correct?**

A) You should to eat fruit.

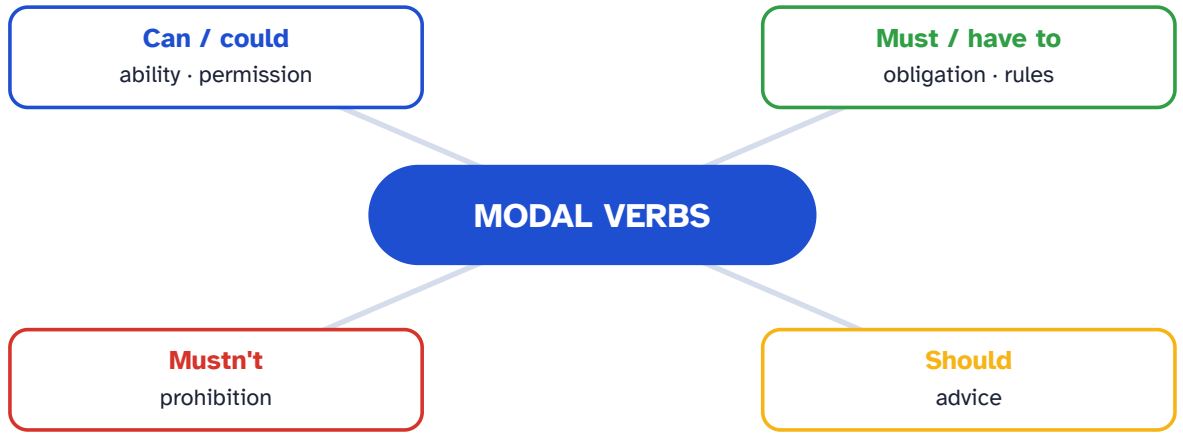
B) You should eat fruit.

C) You shoulds eat fruit.

Explícalo con tus palabras

Incluye: Qué son los verbos modales y sus tres reglas; Para qué sirve can y su pasado could; Diferencia entre must, mustn't y don't have to; Cómo se da un consejo con should.

Resumen



Tarjetas de repaso

Recórtalas: pregunta delante, respuesta detrás.

can

Capacidad o permiso: I can swim.

could

Pasado de can o petición educada.

must

Obligación: You must stop.

mustn't

Prohibición: You mustn't run.

have to

Obligación (cambia: has to).

don't have to

No hace falta.

should

Consejo: You should rest.

Golden rules

Sin -s, sin to, sin do.

Soluciones

1. **B)** Capacidad.
2. **C)** Sin -s.
3. **A)** Sin do.
4. **C)** Could.
5. **B)** Prohibición.
6. **A)** Consejo.
7. **B)** No es necesario.
8. **C)** Permiso.
9. **A)** He + has to.
10. **B)** Sin to, sin -s.

Soluciones de los ejercicios

1. Model answer: I can swim. I can draw. I can't play the piano.
2. Can you speak French?
3. I could read when I was six.
4. Can I go out, please? / Could I go out, please?
5. mustn't.
6. don't have to.
7. You should rest / You should take a break.
8. She must do her homework.
9. You shouldn't watch so much TV.
10. Model answer: You must be quiet. You mustn't eat. You can borrow three books.